



MONTHLY UPDATE

South Sudan: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-06 · 32 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Identity documents and training were the month's deliverables. School-based national identity card registration [opened for examination candidates at a Juba secondary school on 4 August, with expansion stated](#), the outgoing immigration chief [gave passport stock and tenure figures at the handover of the directorate](#), and the education ministry [launched an education-in-emergencies management information system after training 35 master trainers](#).

Connectivity got more expensive and no easier to check. The information minister [publicly defended the telecommunications tariff increase on 24 August](#), which the regulator maintains is an exchange-rate revision rather than a tariff rise, and the revised rates are still unpublished. Regionally, East African states [opened a joint bank account to fund a communications-satellite feasibility study, with deposits due by 30 September](#). A national payment system bill [went through a five-day validation workshop in Juba](#), and an ICT authority [is being established while the legislation for it is still awaited](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The interoperability blueprint is still a purchase order. The ICT ministry's current-projects page, as it stood on 29 August, [lists hiring a firm to develop a Government Enterprise Architecture and implementation plan as active work](#) under the World Bank-financed regional digital integration project. Nothing adopted sits behind it, and the data governance strategy that would run alongside it is at tender too.

Legislation and regulation

On 5 August 2026 the information minister [briefed the President on establishing an ICT Authority as a state entity under the ICT ministry](#), to regulate internet service providers. The report states the initiative aims to put a regulator in place while the government awaits the passage of legislation through parliament. Neither point that follows is addressed: a body constituted before its statute has no enforcement powers over the providers it is meant to license, and the country already has a National Communication Authority, so the division of competence is unstated. The stated justification is youth employment. An account of 21 May 2026 states that the President signed the Authority's legal framework; the two have not been reconciled.

The other statute in play has a text and a process behind it. The central bank and parliament [opened a five-day workshop on 10 August to validate the National Payment System Bill, 2025](#), covering mobile money, electronic money, payment switches and real-time gross settlement with licensing, consumer-protection and systemic-risk provisions, backed by the East African Community secretariat and the Bank of Uganda. On 17 August the governor

called for faster progress toward passage, framing it as the condition for reducing the country's reliance on cash. No bill text, introduction date or parliamentary timetable is held, and the national instant payment system it would license has been Planned since early 2025.

Data protection

There is still no data protection authority, and the communications regulator carries the function in its absence. Its own overview describes a statutory mandate under the National Communication Act 2012 that [includes information protection and data privacy](#) alongside telecommunications, broadcasting and postal regulation. A sector regulator holding a privacy function inside a telecoms mandate is what the country has instead of an authority, and the Bill that would create one has not left drafting.

Regional collaboration

The one regional move in the window is a pledge without a workplan. On 12 August the minister [visited the African Telecommunications Union's Nairobi headquarters and pledged deeper collaboration on infrastructure, capacity building and standardisation](#). No workplan, contribution or membership status is stated, and it sits alongside the payment-system bill validated the same month with East African Community and Bank of Uganda backing — the substantive regional support in this record runs through that bill rather than through the union.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The e-government contract came under an allegation the minister denies. The information technology minister [denied two documents alleging a US\\$15 million influence-buying transfer by the contracted firms](#). The documents' authenticity is contested and the record held carries no independent verification either way. Separately, a published argument [held that South Sudan needs digital payments but also needs the ability to follow the money](#) — a case the month's other news makes concrete.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Prices rose and the numbers behind them did not appear. The information minister [publicly defended the telecommunications tariff increase on 24 August](#); the regulator maintains it is a revision of the exchange rate used to calculate charges rather than a tariff increase, and neither regulator nor operators have published the revised rates. A cost defended without a price is a position the base can record and a reader cannot check.

Regionally, East African states [opened a joint bank account to fund a feasibility study for a communications satellite, with deposits due by 30 September 2026](#). No contribution figure for this country, study scope or reporting date is stated.

Data Storage

The only nationally owned data centre in the base is a [Tier 2 facility at Hai Malakal in Juba](#) offering colocation, hosting, data management, backup and replication, run by a South Sudanese-owned operator and commissioned in 2019. No capacity figure or power rating is published, and no second national provider appears.

Energy

Two connections completed in one week. A project [connecting more than 400 customers in the border town of Nimule](#) on imported Ugandan power launched on 15 August, and two days later government and a development agency handed over a [150 kWp solar plant with 200 kWh of battery storage giving continuous power to the Aweil Regional Reference Laboratory](#) in Northern Bahr el Ghazal.

The larger supply picture moved too: the energy minister reported on 18 August that [transmission works are advancing to bring Ugandan hydropower to Juba through Nimule](#), with a distribution substation already built at Nesitu. Against a rural population almost entirely unserved, four hundred customers is the scale of what completed.

DPI

Data Exchange

The only description the base holds of how import revenue is actually collected is an account of a sanctioned contractor collecting it. A UK-registered firm [manages national revenue through a US-dollar e-Permit charge levied on imports before any tax assessment is issued, enforced at all border points by the Ugandan and Kenyan revenue authorities alongside the firm's own staff deployed under national revenue authority cover](#), and collection has continued since the United States sanctioned the firm on 12 May over the diversion of public resources and foreign assistance. The Tanzanian and Rwandan revenue authorities have publicly dissociated themselves. No contract, legal instrument or revenue figure is published, and no national authority is recorded as answering the account.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The World Bank published its ID4D country diagnostic on 22 July 2026, putting [close to 90% of the population without any government-recognised identification](#). It records that obtaining the Nationality Certificate, the prerequisite for the identity card, requires costly age assessments or blood tests and travel to centralised offices, so most people acquire neither.

On 28 July the civil-registry directorate's plan also included [a digital national identity card to be issued to every citizen aged 18 and over as the gateway to bank accounts](#), delivery running through the health, justice and interior ministries with unnamed partners. It is [stated as intent only](#): no law, budget, timetable, vendor or platform is named.

The directorate says a [new-generation passport will be introduced in August 2027](#), moving the holder's occupation off the printed page into the digital system; raising ordinary validity from five to ten years, and issuing the East African Community passport, would each require amending the passport act, and no legislative timetable is given. It also [received 37,500 further passport booklets, putting stock at enough to sustain issuance to December 2026](#) with processing at about three days, and in Greater Yei [over 4,000 national identity cards began being collected on 13 July](#).

The directorate changed hands on 9 August, and both officeholders put numbers on the record. The outgoing director [put stock at about 32,000 passport booklets and 172,000 national identity cards, alongside 100 new mobile registration kits, a Nairobi memorandum toward an integrated civil registration system, and adult passport validity extended to ten years](#) — claims made at his own handover about his own tenure. His successor [put annual applicants above one million and delays at about a month](#), pledging faster and corruption-free issuance.

The largest registration actually carried out in the window was not the state's. The migration agency ran a [biometric registration and re-registration exercise across the Malakal protection-of-civilians site, the Bulakat transit centre and the Bentiu displacement camp, serving about 160,000 people between April and June](#), and its community-feedback data records an 1,100% rise in queries over the quarter, driven almost entirely by that exercise. No data-controller arrangement, retention rule, consent record or relationship to the national identity system is stated for it.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Financial technology gained a supporter rather than a system. Support for the sector [was reported in August from a foreign government](#), with no value, instrument, recipient or programme document held. Separately the national payment system bill [went through a five-day validation workshop in Juba](#) and remains a bill.

Registries

Four months before the poll, the electoral register does not exist. After assessment missions across all ten states and the three administrative areas, the elections commission said on 21 August that [voter registration was expected to begin soon](#) ahead of the 22 December polls. The exercise is expected to take about a month, and nothing on file records it starting.

Sectoral management information systems

On 5 August the education ministry [launched an Education in Emergencies Management Information System on the DHIS2 platform](#) with UNESCO and the HISP Centre, funded by Education Cannot Wait, after training 35 master trainers; twelve County Education Departments have been equipped with solar power, computers and connectivity to feed it.

Capacity

Literacy

Renovation began in August on [three government facilities designated as digital skills centres in Central Equatoria](#) under a five-year programme aimed partly at civil servants. It is the first physical training capacity in the base, and it lands against a service whose digital literacy has been described as low since 2023 and never measured.

Training and skills

Two private training deliverables closed the month. A mobile operator's money arm [graduated 1,225 entrepreneurs from a digital-finance skills programme on 24 August](#), and the same operator [opened an ICT hub at Aweil in Northern Bahr el Ghazal](#). Both are the operator's own programmes and its own figures; no state training line stands beside them on this ledger.

Inclusion

Access to services

Access got dearer and the machinery for questioning it got weaker, in the same week. A published account reports [internet subscription tariffs rising by approximately 15 per cent across both operators](#) at a time the writer describes the economy as already struggling - an opinion column is the whole of the evidence, with no tariff schedule or regulator approval on file. Separately the state's own human rights commission [rated the country weak on transparency and participation and very weak on accountability, said access to public information remained limited, and heard that the body responsible for access to information lacks the staff and capacity to enforce the law](#).

Geopolitics

China activities

On 31 August the ICT minister was reported to have [held exploratory talks with a Huawei vice-president in Hangzhou, on the sidelines of a China-Africa digital capacity building conference](#), saying the government is ready to seek the company's expertise in connecting public services. Beyond e-governance, participation is sought in building smart cities, providing energy solutions and setting up a national data hub in Juba.

This is a repair, not an opening. [Government officials accused the company in 2014 of hacking government emails and forging documents; it stayed in the market through the rift, connecting schoolchildren to the internet and refurbishing school laboratories, and the restoration is credited to two officials who took post in 2025, whose](#)

[meeting in Juba in early 2026 covered the digital divide, the data hub and a smart capital](#). Nothing has been agreed: no contract, memorandum, workstream or figure is on record, which is where this relationship stood in February and where it still stands.

Gulf/UAE activities

The legislature [ratified the general cooperation agreement with Saudi Arabia](#) on 19 August, three months after rejecting it on sovereignty grounds. The agreement, signed in 2022, covers agriculture, education, mining, infrastructure, health, trade, investment, security and social development. No digital or data commitment appears in it.

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